

Maintenance and support

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In a perfect world, software would be error-free, customers would love it, and there would be no need for maintenance and support. In reality, software is in constant evolution, guided by the interaction of developers and customers.

The support desk

The first step towards logging a problem with software is to contact the support desk. Support staff provide assistance by phone, email, or chat. Their tasks might include walking through basic setups, troubleshooting compatibility issues, or discovering new bugs. Big companies often have specialized support staff, while developers in smaller businesses take turns at being on-call. In-person help can also be obtained at a support desk.

▷ Support channels

There are numerous options to connect users to support staff. Often the urgency of the problem determines which one a person needing help will use.



Phone call



Email



Chat



Video call

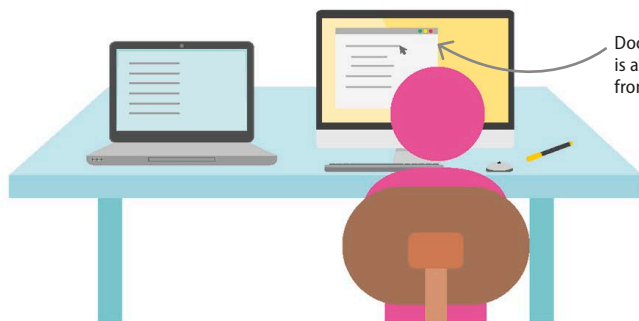
Documentation

Usually, new software comes with a user guide or manual. It might also come with a tutorial or how-to videos or articles. These are all called documentation. For clients, documentation covers basic tasks and common problems, such as how to reset a password or change a profile picture. Developers may also include documentation in the software for other developers to see that gives an overview of the software code. However, many companies see documentation as a bonus, and neglect it in favour of bug fixes and new features.



△ For clients

Good documentation covers all the basics. The majority of clients should be able to solve their problems by viewing these online resources. While support staff are important, they can only help a few customers at once.



Documentation is a separate file from the code.

◁ For developers

Documentation talks about the logic and the design of a system. It helps new team members figure out the code, and also serves as a refresher for experienced developers. Documentation is a separate resource from in-code comments.